

The 11 Rothschild children shared one tiny bedroom. The first Rothschild banking house was a back room measuring 10 square feet. Gutle cooked for her family in a small passage about four feet wide with space on the hearth for only a single pot. There was hardly any furniture, just a bench and a small chest.

Somehow, in this grim setting, Gutle created a harmonious and industrious home. She was prudent, frugal, and very religious, but also warm and loving.³

She worked very hard and demanded the same of her children. She, along with her husband, instilled in them a sense of duty to the family and to each other.

The family unity continued for generations. Against overwhelming odds, they have successfully grown family wealth for over 250 years.

The youngest of the children, James, as an adult remarked, “It is only the reputation, the happiness and the unity of the family which lies close to my heart, and it is as a result of our business dealings that we remain united. If one shares and receives the accounts every day, then everything will stay united, God willing.”⁴

And the Rothschild brothers did stay united, even after the Vienna office imploded due to bad investments. They reorganized and went on to build the most successful network of investment banking businesses the world had ever seen.

But even as the family fortune grew and her children became powerbrokers across Europe, Gutle lived in the same old house in the ghetto for the rest of her life. She kept the family anchored in their humble beginnings.

Gutle died on May 7, 1849, at age 96, with her surviving sons at her bedside.

The loss of their mother, even at her great age, deeply affected the second generation of Rothschilds.

Gutle Rothschild played a huge role in her children’s emotional lives. A great matriarch gives balance to family members by helping fulfill their emotional needs. She provides for them and makes them feel loved. And this is what builds the family side of the family wealth equation.